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The penny saved is what they yearn

Trump wants to kill it, but pro-cent lobby has other ideas

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When President Trump said Sunday night that he would direct the Treasury to stop producing the penny in order to cut costs, he may have wagered that the increasingly irrelevant coins wouldn't be missed outside the confines of couch cushions and piggy banks.

But there is a constituency for every federal initiative, even the beleaguered penny. And its assorted makers and boosters are anxiously hoping Trump doesn't make the change.

For decades, just one company has been responsible for producing the zinc-based metal disks that become pennies: Artazn, which is headquartered in Greene County, Tenn.

The zinc used for the pennies comes from a processing plant in Mooresboro, N.C.; a transportation network takes the zinc from there to Ten-

PENNIES, Page A9



DAVID ZALUBOWSKI/ASSOCIATED PRESS/FILE

Billions of pennies are produced each year, and each costs 3 cents to make.

Win for Trump

A judge in Boston ruled a buyout offer to 2 million federal workers can proceed, and lifted a temporary pause. **B1.**

Much at stake

Mass. universities, hospitals, and research institutions would lose millions if Trump carries out his plans. **D1.**

3%
inflation rate on consumer prices for January, a higher-than-expected bump that strengthens the case for the Fed to continue holding off cutting interest rates. **D1.**

Trump says Putin is ready to talk peace

In call, presidents commit to work together; Ukraine could be left on sidelines

By Maggie Haberman, Zolan Kanno-Youngs, and Anton Troianovski
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Wednesday that he had a “lengthy and highly productive phone call” with President Vladimir Putin of Russia, characterizing it as the beginning of a negotiation to end the war in Ukraine.

It was the first confirmed conversation between the two men during Trump's second term, coming as Trump has made clear to advisers that finding a US-backed end to the war that Russia began is a priority for his administration.

“We each talked about the strengths of our respective Nations, and the great benefit that we will someday have in working together,” Trump wrote in a social media post. “But first, as we both agreed, we want to stop the millions of deaths taking place in the War with Russia/Ukraine.” (An estimated several hundred thousand deaths have occurred in the conflict, not millions.)

For Putin, the call was a major milestone, signifying the collapse of Western efforts to isolate him diplomatically after he invaded Ukraine nearly three years ago. Ever since Trump's reelection in November, the Russian president has heaped praise on Trump, underlining the Kremlin's hope that the new American leader could reshape Moscow's relationship with Washington and back away from supporting Ukraine.

The conversation between the two presidents

TRUMP, Page A9

US takes Mass. to task on special ed

Report lists 10 ways state is failing to comply

By Mandy McLaren
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts has failed to ensure local school districts are providing special education students with the services and protections they are entitled to under federal law, the US Department of Education has concluded in a long-awaited review.

In a report made public Tuesday night, the Department's Office of Special Education Pro-

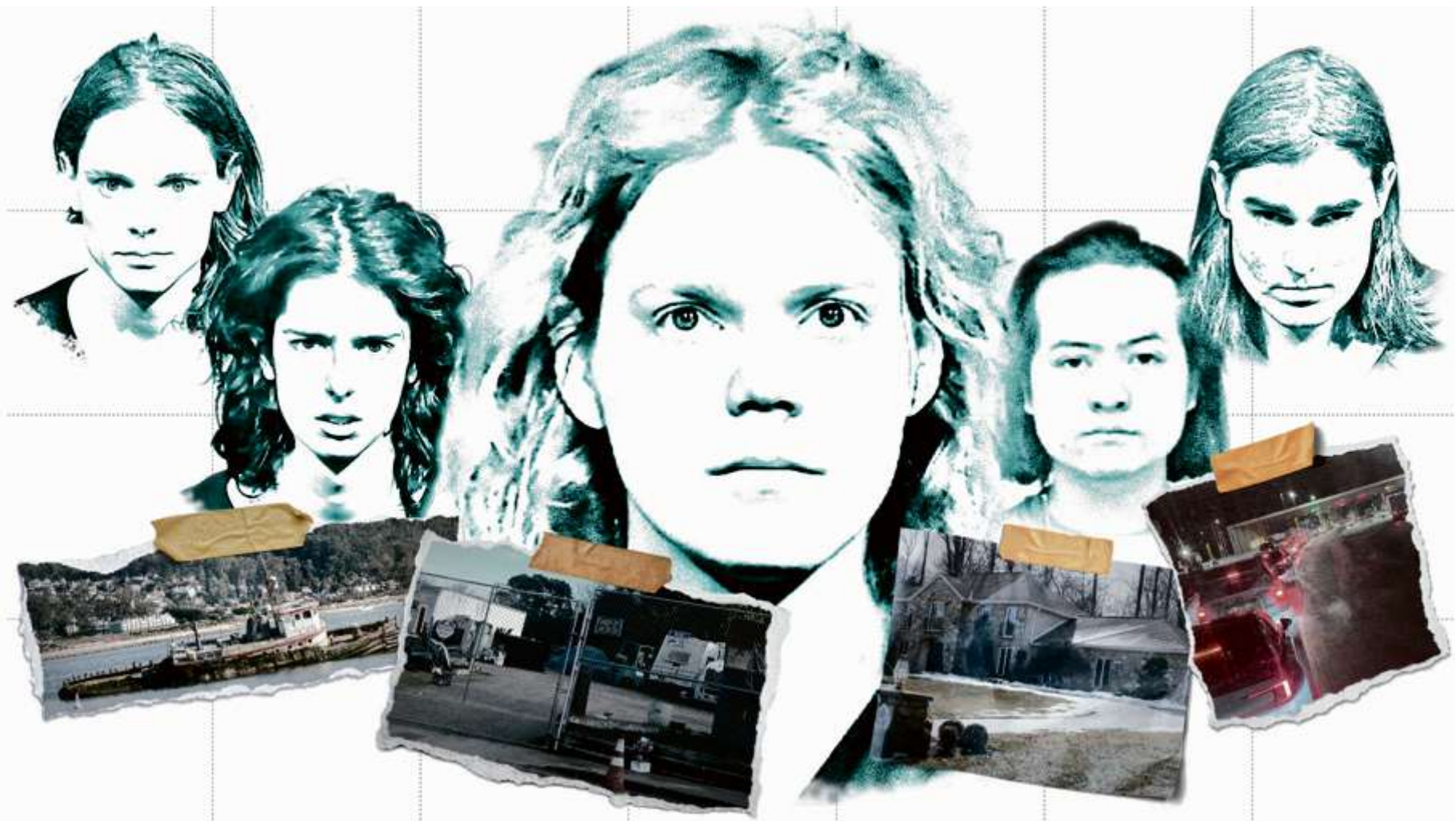
► **Audit planned in Brookline over alleged mismanagement of special education. B1.**

grams identified 10 ways in which the state Education Department is not complying with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, the federal law guaranteeing disabled students the right to a free and appropriate public education. Those range in scope from parents not being told the full extent of their rights, to students languishing for months on end without needed support.

State agencies are required to hold local districts and schools accountable to the law in exchange for receiving federal education funding. The noncompliance now puts some \$340 million the state receives annually for special education at risk.

Jacqueline Reis, a spokesperson for the Massachusetts De-

SPECIAL ED, Page A12



ASHLEY BORG/GLOBE STAFF

INSIDE THE ZIZIANS: MESMERIC MAYHEM

By Hanna Krueger, Laura Crimaldi, and Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

Rita and Richard Zajko received two visitors just before midnight on New Year's Eve in 2022. The duo stayed less than 20 minutes, images recorded by a neighbor's Ring camera show. They arrived by car, pulling into the horseshoe driveway of the couple's suburban Philadelphia home and killing the headlights. A minute or two later, someone shouted: “Mom!” Seconds later, the camera captured another

Shootout and death of Border Patrol agent on Vt. highway is latest brutal case tied to group

shout: “Oh my God! Oh, God! God!”

The lights in the Zajkos' bedroom flickered on. Nine minutes later, the car rumbled away. The new year arrived. Two days passed before the authorities found the Zajkos' bodies in their bedroom.

They'd been shot in the head.

Police worked to allay neighbors' concerns with assurances that the murder was not “a random act,” hinting they had leads on prospective killers.

Indeed, in the days after the bodies were found, Pennsylvania State Police tracked down the couple's daughter, Michelle. The Ring footage revealed the suspicious New Year's Eve visit. A recent text from Rita to Michelle made note of a savings bond about to mature. And months earlier, Michelle had purchased a handgun and ammunition in Vermont of the same type used to kill her parents.

ZIZIANS, Page A6

Despite sale to trust, Maine papers are still struggling

By Aidan Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

When the nonprofit National Trust for Local News acquired the Portland Press Herald, The Sun Journal in Lewiston, and 20 other Maine newspapers in 2023, it was seen by employees as a god-send.

The new owners vowed to protect the jobs of Maine journalists even while seeking to modernize operations. Though the National Trust was facing the same economic challenges as other newspaper owners, its charitable origins — and its \$38 million in philanthropic funding — felt different.

“We took a huge amount of heart in the fact that the National Trust's mission is to support local news,” said Megan Gray, president of the News Guild of Maine and an arts and culture reporter at the Press Herald.

But a year and a half in, the Maine papers are facing persistent financial losses. Freelance budgets are being cut, newspapers are getting thinner,

MAINE PAPERS, Page A12

The Gaza cease-fire could be endangered because the delivery of tents and temporary homes may fall short of the agreement. **A3.**

New England universities saw the values of their endowments grow by nearly 9 percent last year, fueled by a strong economy. **D1.**

The Senate confirmed Tulsi Gabbard to be the next director of national intelligence, in a 52-48 vote. **A2.**

Physicists have uncovered evidence of a ghostly subatomic particle catapulting through space at a speed hardly dreamed of. **A2.**

A magazine publisher was ordered to provide prosecutors with audio recordings of interviews the husband of Lindsay Clancy, who allegedly killed her children, gave to The New Yorker. **B2.**



Splash, done

Thursday: Wet early, mild. High 42-47. Low 23-28.

Friday: Sunny but windy. High 30-35. Low 17-22.

High tide: 11:43 a.m.

Sunrise: 6:43 Sunset: 5:14

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C11.

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DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

A NICE WAY TO GET STARTED FOR SOX



On the day of the first official workout for pitchers and catchers in Fort Myers (above, manager Alex Cora checked in with veteran Aroldis Chapman), the Red Sox made big news Wednesday night by agreeing to a three-year deal with former Astros star Alex Bregman for \$120 million. **C1-2.**